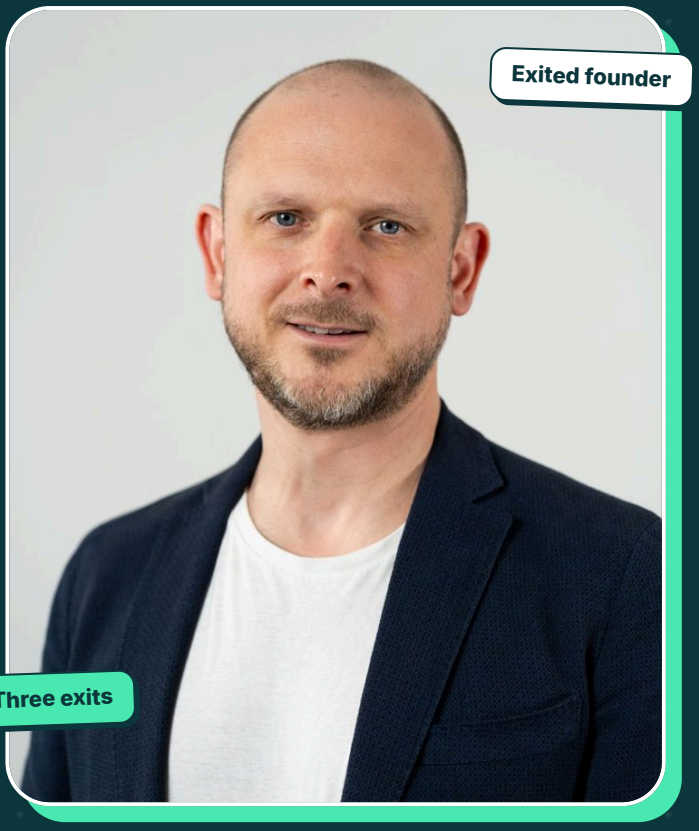
Revenue&Beyond.

FREE GUIDE · FOR B2B FOUNDERS

The founder-led sales blueprint.

How to get sales out of your head and into a system that grows, holds and sells without you.



07
parts, each with actions to take this month

20
minutes to read end to end

01
scorecard to show where sales still depends on you

Simon Watson
Founder, Revenue & Beyond

What is inside

Seven parts and a scorecard. Read it once end to end, then go back to the part where you scored lowest.

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HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

1. **Read it end to end once.** It takes about twenty minutes.
2. **Do the scorecard** in part 07.
3. **Go back to your lowest score** and do that part's actions.
4. **Score yourself again** in 90 days.

You're the reason it's growing. You're also the reason it's stuck.



Simon Watson
Exited founder. Three exits: an IPO, a trade sale and a VC-backed sale.

Most of the founder-led businesses I work with have the same shape. Revenue is coming in, the clients are good, the team is capable, and almost every deal still runs through one person. The founder finds the work, has the first conversation, writes the proposal, sets the price and, more often than not, closes it as well.

That works up to a point, and it is how I got my own business off the ground in the first place. The problem is that it doesn't scale, it doesn't survive a proper holiday, and it doesn't survive a buyer looking hard at the business. Buyers don't pay for revenue. They pay for a business that works without the founder in it.

I have been through three exits, once as the founder and twice inside the senior leadership team, and I have spent 20+ years selling and scaling B2B businesses across EMEA. This blueprint is the sequence I come back to every time a founder tells me sales is "fine", but everything still depends on them.

It isn't theory. Every part ends with the actions to take this month. Work through it in order, be honest with yourself on the scorecard at the end, and you will know exactly where your sales still lean on you.

Simon

"Buyers don't pay for revenue. They pay for a business that works without the founder in it."

Who you choose matters more than how many

Most founders describe their ideal client as a job title and a company size. That is a filter, not a decision. At any one time only 1 to 3% of your market is actually in a position to buy, so the real work is choosing the few hundred businesses where you are genuinely the right answer, and being known to them before they are ready.

When I ask a founder to describe their best client, the useful answer is never the sector. It is the moment they picked up the phone: what had just gone wrong, who made the call, and what they had already tried.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

A one-page ideal client profile, written down, that covers:

- The trigger that makes them look for help
- The problem, in their own words
- Who signs and who influences
- What they have already tried
- A clear list of who it isn't for

TAKE ACTION

1. **Study your best ten.** Pull your ten best clients and write down what they had in common beyond sector and size: the moment they came to you, what had just broken, who made the decision.
2. **Write the "not for" list.** If you can't name who you would turn away, you haven't really chosen.
3. **Name the accounts.** Build a named list of 100 to 300 businesses that match. Not a database of 5,000.
4. **Describe their world in one sentence.** A sentence a founder in that business would recognise as their own. It becomes your opener, your homepage line and your first question on a call.

The founder trap Saying yes to everything because the pipeline feels thin. Every wrong-fit client uses up the time you needed for the right ones.

Stages that mean something

Most pipelines I review look healthy in the meeting and stall at stage two or three. Very few move to contract. Nine times out of ten that is because the stages describe what the seller did ("sent proposal", "followed up") rather than what the buyer has agreed to.

FIVE STAGES, DEFINED BY THE BUYER

	STAGE	IT ONLY MOVES ON WHEN THE BUYER HAS...
1	**Conversation**	Agreed there is a problem worth exploring
2	**Diagnosis**	Shared the numbers, the cost of the problem and who decides
3	**Shape agreed**	Heard the approach and the price, out loud, before anything is written
4	**Decision**	Put the decision maker in the room and confirmed a date and process
5	**Signed**	Signed

FOUR QUESTIONS BEFORE ANYTHING COUNTS AS PIPELINE

1. Is the problem real, and is it costing them money?
2. Who signs, and have I spoken to them?
3. Is there a reason to act now rather than next quarter?
4. Can they afford to fix it?

If you can't answer at least two of the four, it isn't pipeline. It's hope.

TAKE ACTION

1. **Write the stages down.** Define each one by what the buyer has done, and share it with anyone who touches a deal.
2. **Clean the CRM.** Anything with no buyer action in 30 days moves back a stage or comes out.
3. **No surprise proposals.** The proposal confirms a decision, it doesn't make one.
4. **Review it weekly.** Same day, same time, same five numbers (part 06).

The founder trap — Holding the pipeline in your head. If it isn't in the CRM, it doesn't exist for anyone else, including your next hire and your eventual buyer.

Outreach that actually gets a reply

AI and automation have made outbound louder, and less effective. Most founders have responded by sending more: more sequences, more tools, more "scale". Buyers have learned to ignore all of it.

The founders getting replies now use AI differently. It does the digging, and a human does the talking. Every channel has a job, and nothing goes out that couldn't have been written by someone who had spent time on the other person's world. And it starts with who you target, not how many.

WHAT THE SYSTEM DELIVERS FOR THE FOUNDERS I WORK WITH

70%
LinkedIn connection rate

70%
Reply rate on LinkedIn

20%
Pick-up rate on the phone

30%
Of answered calls booked into a meeting

6 to 8 **New meetings a week** for clients who fully embed the system.

Email moves deals forward and closes them, without the dreaded ghosting.

Measured over the past six months. Volume isn't the point: who you target matters far more than how many.

TAKE ACTION

1. **Research before you reach.** Spend time on their world before every message. AI can do the digging, but it can't tell you what matters to them.
2. **Lead with their world, not your service.** Your first message should be about them, not about what you do.
3. **Never pitch on the first touch.** And never repeat the same angle in a follow-up.
4. **Give each channel a job.** LinkedIn starts the conversation, the phone deepens it, and email moves the deal forward. Email is not for chasing.
5. **Keep it human-sized.** Twenty to twenty-five personal messages a day beats two thousand automated ones.

THE BLUEPRINT

Working with me, you get my exact blueprint for outbound: how I use AI across LinkedIn, the phone and email to get these numbers, and how email keeps deals moving without the ghosting. It's the part I build with founders directly.

Book a free Diagnosis Call

The founder trap Using AI to send more, instead of to say something better.

Diagnose before you prescribe

Founders are usually brilliant on a sales call because nobody knows the product better. That is also why they pitch too early. The best first conversations spend most of their time on the buyer's world, and the pitch, when it comes, is short because it answers something they have already told you.

It is also worth remembering that the problem a client describes on the first call is rarely the real one. Your job is to find the real one.

FIVE DIAGNOSIS QUESTIONS

1. What made you take this call now?
2. What have you already tried, and why didn't it stick?
3. What is it costing you every month it stays the same?
4. Who else will have a view on this, and what will they care about?
5. If this was fixed, what would be different in six months?

ON PRICE

Flat fees and firm anchors. Say the price plainly, then stop talking. Don't soften it in the conversation, and don't discount to close. A discount tells the buyer the first number wasn't real.

MOST OBJECTIONS ARE A MISSED STEP

WHAT THEY SAY	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENED EARLIER
"It's too expensive."	The cost of the problem was never established
"Now isn't the right time."	There was no reason to act now
"I need to run it past my partner."	You haven't met the person who decides
"Can you send something over?"	The diagnosis never happened

TAKE ACTION

1. **Write your five questions.** Ask them on every first call before you say what you do.
2. **Listen back.** Record your calls and review one a week. Note how many minutes in you started pitching.
3. **Trace your objections.** List your five most common and match each to the step that was skipped.
4. **Never end without a next step.** Agree the next step and the date before every call finishes.

The founder trap Accepting the client's diagnosis of their own problem, and selling them the fix they asked for.

Build the system before you hire the seller

The failed sales hire is one of the most common, and most expensive, stories I hear. A founder hires a good salesperson to take the load, six to nine months later it hasn't worked, and the founder is back in every deal, more convinced than ever that "nobody can sell it like me".

Usually the hire wasn't the problem. There was simply no system for them to sell inside.

HAVE THESE IN PLACE BEFORE THEY START

- A written ideal client profile and a named account list (part 01)
- Pipeline stages defined by the buyer (part 02)
- A sales story and case studies that someone other than you can tell
- Pricing and discount rules, written down
- Warm relationships to hand over, with personal introductions
- A 30/60/90 day plan with ramped targets you agree together

TAKE ACTION

1. **Write down how you sell.** As if for a new starter on day one. If you can't, that is the first job, and it comes before the job advert.
2. **Hire for your stage.** Someone who has built sales in a business your size, not a big-logo account manager who has always had a machine behind them.
3. **Ramp the target.** Nobody hits full quota in month one. Agree the ramp in writing.
4. **Hand over real relationships.** Introduce them personally. A cold list is not a handover.

The founder trap Hiring to get yourself out of sales, then quietly staying in every deal. The hire never owns anything, and you end up paying for two people to do one job.

Five numbers, every week

You don't need a dashboard with forty metrics. You need five numbers, on one page, reviewed at the same time every week.

1. **New conversations started**
   The leading indicator. If this drops, everything else drops a quarter later.

2. **Pipeline value by stage**
   And how it compares to your target for the next two quarters.

3. **Stage conversion**
   Where deals stall tells you which step is broken.

4. **Sales cycle length**
   If it is getting longer, find out why before it shows up in the revenue.

5. **Founder dependency**
   The share of pipeline where you are the main relationship. This is the number a buyer will care about most, and the one almost nobody tracks.

TAKE ACTION

1. **One page, 30 minutes, every week.** Same time, same five numbers, no exceptions.
2. **Set a dependency target.** Pick a number for founder dependency and bring it down every quarter.
3. **Ask why, not what.** For each number that moves the wrong way, write one line on why.

The founder trap Tracking activity because it is easy to count, and missing the one number that decides whether you can step back or sell.

How much does your sales depend on you?

Score each statement honestly. Circle **0** if it is not true, **1** if it is partly true, **2** if it is true.

	STATEMENT	YOUR SCORE
1	I could hand someone my ideal client profile, and who it isn't for, in writing today.	0 1 2
2	I have a named list of target accounts, not just a set of search filters.	0 1 2
3	Every pipeline stage is defined by what the buyer has done.	0 1 2
4	My pipeline lives in a CRM that someone else could pick up tomorrow.	0 1 2
5	More than half of new conversations start without me personally.	0 1 2
6	Someone other than me can run a first call and qualify it properly.	0 1 2
7	My pricing is written down and I don't discount to close.	0 1 2
8	I could give a new sales hire a written playbook on day one.	0 1 2
9	I review the same five numbers every week.	0 1 2
10	If I stepped away for 90 days, the pipeline would keep moving.	0 1 2

YOUR TOTAL OUT OF 20

0 to 7

It all runs through you.

That is normal at this stage, and it is fixable. Start with parts 01 and 02.

8 to 14

The foundations are there, but they still lean on you.

Go to the part behind your lowest scores and do those actions first.

15 to 20

You are close to sales that runs without you.

The work now is making it visible, in the numbers, to the team and eventually to a buyer.

Want a second pair of eyes?



If you scored under 15, or you scored well and something still feels stuck, that is exactly the conversation I have with founders every week.

The free Diagnosis Call is 30 minutes. I will look at how sales works in your business today, where it still depends on you, and what I would fix first. No pitch, no agenda.

Book a free Diagnosis Call revenueandbeyond.com/book

WHY FOUNDERS LISTEN

3 exits
An IPO, a trade sale and a VC-backed sale

20+ years
Selling and scaling B2B businesses across EMEA

8-figure
Exit for a founder-led agency in 2 years and 2 months

£2m
Pipeline built for an enterprise software vendor, £300k closed in 8 months

> **"Simon was integral to all of it."**
>
> **Simon Wardropper**, Co-Founder & CEO, Realtime Agency. £4m revenue growth, a £3m Breitling contract and an 8-figure exit in 2 years and 2 months.

Revenue&Beyond.

Build, scale and sell your B2B business.
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